

Academic integrity is under fire in the Generative AI age: insights from accounting educators to overcome challenges, threats and ethical concerns

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Abstract

Purpose – This study investigates the challenges and threats of Generative AI to academic integrity as well as seeks to gain insights from accounting educators to overcome the challenges identified.

Design/methodology/approach – The research methodology followed a qualitative approach. This involved the use of semi-structured interviews among 17 accounting instructors from different UK universities. This method allowed for the extraction of thematic patterns related to the factors mentioned above.

Findings – The results suggest that GenAI hold many ethical issues and concerns like academic misconduct, overreliance, accuracy and bias, transparency and information privacy, which should be addressed. To ensure ethical and effective use, academics highlight the importance of the strategic incorporation of AI in teaching, new forms of assessment, academic policies concerning AI use, besides AI literacy training.

Practical implications – The findings from this research provide actionable recommendations to educators, higher education institutions and policymakers. Among the actions that should be taken in universities are AI guidelines, clear policies and regularity framework. Furthermore, this may include the dissemination of AI literacy among the students and faculty members, as well as the implementation of training programs for AI. Apart from this, the use of assessment tools for the support of higher-order thinking that are AI-friendly should also be considered.

Originality/value – This research makes a contribution to the existing body of knowledge related to AI in higher education in general and accounting education specifically in the area of exploring the views of educators on the issues of academic integrity, ethics in the digital age and AI-based teaching methodologies. This research offers a very important perspective to the debate related to the inclusion of AI in higher education.

Keywords Generative AI in higher education, Academic integrity, AI misuse, AI ethics, AI threats, Accounting education

Paper type Research article

1. Introduction

The applications of Generative AI (GenAI) in higher education highlight its potential to offer multiple advantages to the educational environment. The positive impact of GenAI can be seen in enhanced teaching and learning approaches, improved learning outcomes, greater global access to quality education and increased time and cost efficiency, among other benefits (Jiao, 2024). Intelligent tutoring features and personalized learning experiences provided by GenAI can help bolster learning outcomes, particularly for students in underserved and underrepresented communities. The scalability and outreach of AI enable students from both developed and developing countries to benefit equally from improved learning experiences (Wood and Moss, 2024).

Despite the benefits that GenAI offers to the educational environment – where it can be ethically employed as a complementary learning aid for brainstorming, clarifying complex materials and supporting technical tasks when properly acknowledged and not used as a substitute for human effort (Wood *et al.*, 2023; Choi *et al.*, 2023; Ballantine *et al.*, 2024) – its unethical use nevertheless poses significant threats and challenges. The ethical concerns associated with GenAI include academic misconduct, such as inaccuracy, dishonesty, cheating and plagiarism (Chan and Hu, 2023; Sweeney, 2023; Dakakni *et al.*, 2023; Ballantine *et al.*, 2024). Consequently, there are



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growing concerns about its impact on academic integrity, particularly in relation to student assignments, evaluation and research (Wood *et al.*, 2023; Ballantine *et al.*, 2024). In this regard, Sweeney (2023) and Dakakni *et al.* (2023) advocate that academic integrity is under serious threat, with students increasingly resorting to AI tools to complete graded assignments, exacerbating academic misconduct in the form of cheating in coursework, assignments and exams to achieve more desirable outcomes. Additionally, GenAI applications still suffer from algorithmic bias, especially in areas related to social inequality, factual errors and misinformation. AI-generated text often lacks accuracy, synthesis and critical analysis, and it may produce inappropriate or fabricated references (Choi *et al.*, 2023). This may pose serious challenges for the contemporary educational environment. Furthermore, data security, privacy risks, social bias and discrimination remain critical concerns that need to be addressed.

Hence, it is evident that the widespread use of continuously evolving GenAI applications, which put academic integrity under fire, lending severe ethical challenges, risks and threats to higher education in general and accounting education in particular. This has led some universities to ban the use of ChatGPT and other generative AI models in the educational process, as well as to implement measures to prevent their unethical use. While these institutions have a right to do so to safeguard academic integrity and maintain the quality of learning outcomes, they might risk losing the potential benefits that GenAI can offer as a valuable learning tool. For instances, GenAI has the capacity to enhance active learning environments and improve student engagement and learning outcomes (Al-Hajaya *et al.*, 2025). Moreover, the integration of AI advancements with educational technology is increasingly seen as inevitable and essential for adapting to the contemporary technological environment. Higher education institutions (HEIs) that resist AI adoption may find themselves lagging behind in the evolving educational landscape. Indeed, some HEIs have already caught this idea and embraced this shift, such as the Chinese company Meten Holding Group, which has launched a ChatGPT-assisted educational platform to drive innovation in the education sector (Cano *et al.*, 2023; Elbanna and Armstrong, 2024).

Accordingly, the airwaves have recently been dominated by discussions on how appropriately utilizing AI in higher education, with voices calling for banning it and others advocate harnessing it within the students' learning experiences. This debate has, unsurprisingly, created more questions than answers. Thus, the current study aims to contribute to the contemporary debate and answer the following questions. What are the ethical challenges and threats of GenAI use in higher education in general and accounting education in particular? How can GenAI be successfully and effectively embraced in education to ensure academic integrity and provide an authentic learning experience? How can the challenges, risks and ethical threats associated with GenAI be addressed, mitigated and managed? What is the anticipated role of educators in controlling the unethical use of GenAI by students?

Building on the ethical challenges and risks associated with the use of GenAI in higher education, the present study seeks to answer these questions by conducting a qualitative investigation with accounting educators at UK universities. While much of the existing literature highlights threats such as academic misconduct, bias, data privacy concerns and a lack of transparency, there remains limited empirical evidence on how these challenges are perceived and managed within specific disciplinary contexts, such as accounting education. To address this gap, the study is guided by the Academic Integrity Framework (Fishman, 2014; Bretag, 2016; Eaton, 2023) and Institutional Theory (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983), which together provide a conceptual foundation for examining how GenAI reshapes academic integrity and how universities respond to such technological disruptions. By capturing the lived experiences and perspectives of accounting educators, this study aims to provide a deeper understanding of how GenAI is reshaping academic integrity, the practical strategies educators are adopting to safeguard ethical standards, and the implications for policy and practice in higher education not only in the UK, but overall in the world.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. Section 2 presents a theoretical framework, and review of the relevant literature on the ethical and unethical uses of generative

AI and its implications for academic integrity in higher education. This is followed by Section 3, the research design and methodology, outlining the participants, data collection process, and thematic analysis. Section 4, the findings and discussion section, then interprets the results in light of prior research, while Section 5, the final section, offers conclusions and practical recommendations for promoting ethical and responsible use of generative AI in accounting education.

2. Theoretical framework and literature review

2.1 Theoretical framework: academic integrity framework and institutional theory

This empirical endeavor has a foundation in two Paradigmatic concepts: the academic integrity framework and institutional theory.

Academic integrity can be described as the adherence to ethical principles and behavior pertaining to teaching, learning and scholarship conducted in a trustworthy, honest and respectful manner toward the creation of knowledge (Fishman, 2014; Bretag, 2016; Eaton, 2023). The framework is based on six core values described by the International Center for Academic Integrity (ICAI) (Fishman, 2014) – honesty, trust, fairness, respect, responsibility and courage. Therefore, the importance of integrity in educational institutions has been described as actions contrary to the core values above, as the basis of academic dishonesty identified as contract cheating, plagiarism, cheating, among other forms of academic dishonesty (Bretag, 2016). In more recent arguments related to the importance of academic integrity in today's institutions of higher education, Eaton (2023) has presented the Comprehensive Academic Integrity Framework. In this framework, integrity is viewed as an ethical stance and an institutional responsibility embedded in policies, pedagogy and community partnerships.

In this context, the role of GenAI appears at the nexus of both risk and opportunity. On the one hand, GenAI can compromise integrity through the facilitation of plagiarism, the loss of authorship clarity and the promotion of dishonest behavior (Bretag, 2016), and on the other hand GenAI can play a positive role in promoting integrity when used ethically for purposes such as the explanation of concepts that are unclear or complicated in their explanation (Wood *et al.*, 2023; Choi *et al.*, 2023; Ballantine *et al.*, 2024). In the context of the framework for academic integrity, the positioning of GenAI enables the current research to critically evaluate the role of its usage at the level of the higher education system and whether the principles of credible scholarship are promoted or undermined.

In parallel with Academic integrity framework, the Institutional Theory (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983) offers a perspective to comprehend the way universities and departments respond to the technological disruption. In this context, the coercive pressure comes from the regulatory authorities and accreditation agencies that enforce AI-related policies. On the other hand, the normative pressure refers to the codes of conduct among academics. Such factors account for the fact that universities can react through policy interventions, training opportunities or new forms of assessment (Zhai, 2024). In this conceptual framework, the reactions to GenAI are neither merely individual nor educational but strategic actions driven by the logics and imperatives of maintaining legitimacy in the rapidly changing context of education.

2.2 Ethical vs unethical use of generative AI in accounting education

Although the literature has identified many threats and opportunities related to GenAI use, the present debate tends to lack clarity in the definition of the use of ethical vs unethical usage in the academic field. This lack of clarity can create confusion in the present debate related to AI and can further create obstacles in formulating effective policies (Đerić *et al.*, 2025).

For the purposes of the present study, ethical GenAI use can be described as following the principles of academic integrity when utilizing GenAI. This involves activities that promote the development process and skills of the learner without involving the pass-off of the output

created as the original human effort produced by a student. In the context of accounting students, the use of GenAI can involve activities such as brainstorming of ideas for completing research papers, improving the writing aspect of assignments completed by the student, summarizing technical accounting materials presented to the student for comprehension, and the explanation of financial ratios as the student acquires new skills related to the interpretation of accounting concepts presented as GenAI output (Wood *et al.*, 2023). In the context described above for the present study, the ethical use of GenAI serves as the positive positioning of the AI tool as playing a role that enables rather than replaces human effort (Ballantine *et al.*, 2024; Choi *et al.*, 2023).

On the other hand, the unethical use of GenAI encompasses actions considered for the purposes of undermining the authenticity of tests or copyrighting false authorship. For instance, generating completed assignments or case-study solutions by students and submitting them as their own work, generating fabricated financial information and sources and utilizing AI for the completion of examination-style questions for accounting without proper disclosure (Chan and Hu, 2023; Dakakni *et al.*, 2023; Ballantine *et al.*, 2024). Such practices contribute to weakening the students' analytical and technological abilities, in addition to erosion of the confidence of the HEIs and their outcomes, creating broader ethical and societal risks (Peres *et al.*, 2023; Zhai, 2024). Beyond misconduct, unethical use also involves the overlooking of broader ethical issues such as bias, a lack of transparency, as well as data privacy violations. To begin with, biased training data may continue perpetuating discrimination, while uninterpretable algorithms, as well as weak data protection, undermine fairness as well as student trust (Đerić *et al.*, 2025).

2.3 Shifting the focus to unethical uses of GenAI in higher education

Albeit the many benefits which may arise from the use of ChatGPT, various threats and unethical breaches need to be noted as the cons of integrating it within the educational environment. The unethical usage of GenAI creates a great deal of challenges for the current educational context. The academic misconduct, such as dishonesty, cheating as well as plagiarism, appeared as the main ethical threats (Chan and Hu, 2023; Sweeney, 2023; Dakakni *et al.*, 2023; Ballantine *et al.*, 2024). Furthermore, concerns arise regarding inaccuracy due to AI hallucinations as well as limitations related to bias, data privacy and security.

GenAI has made cheating easier, faster and more accessible, allowing students to generate essay-style assignments of reasonable quality within seconds (Dale and Drummond, 2024). Consequently, concerns have been raised that various AI chatbot tools may facilitate cheating and plagiarism, as students use them to produce grammatically accurate content sourced from Big Data companies (Choi *et al.*, 2023; Dakakni *et al.*, 2023). In this vein, Ballantine *et al.* (2024) express concerns that if students use AI tools to generate assessment submissions and pass them off as their own work, it poses a significant threat to academic integrity in higher education. Moreover, Wood *et al.* (2023) concluded that while ChatGPT perform fairly well in answering accounting questions, it will have significant implications for accounting education, as they could offer a new means for students to cheat. Thus, Zhai (2024) cautioned that the validity of assessment practices of written assignments might be compromised as a result of the employment of text-to-text generators such as ChatGPT. While cheating and essay mills have long been an issue in academia, the rapid expansion of GenAI has turbo-charged the problem (Dale and Drummond, 2024). Especially, with technology advancing on a daily-basis and the development of some AI-humanization features, plagiarism checkers still fail to detect some AI-generated output, thus making it impossible to identify whether a given piece of work is the student's original work (Peres *et al.*, 2023). Even more concerning, recent experiments with plagiarism detection software indicate that some original human-authored content is falsely flagged as AI-generated, due to the false-positives problem.

AI chatbots still have limited reasoning capabilities when analysing content that involves multiple topics. As a result, large language models (LLMs) are unable to match or replace

human intelligence in achieving a nuanced understanding of abstract concepts (McKinsey, 2023; Zhai *et al.*, 2024). In this context, Choi *et al.* (2023) analysis of AI-generated writing prompts indicated that while the generated text was mostly relevant and original, it lacked critical analysis, synthesis and personal views, often including fabricated and inappropriate references. Furthermore, although GenAI demonstrates strong writing abilities, it typically presents a single perspective and fails to cite sufficient supporting evidence (Cooper, 2023; Zhao *et al.*, 2024). Zhai *et al.* (2024) further underscore concerns regarding ChatGPT, including lack of transparency, legal issues and copyright problems, cybersecurity risks, misinformation and incorrect citations. These are considered great ethical threats to the integrity of the academic and educational environment. Sweeney (2023) argues that resorting to AI mills to generate written work might make students turn out to be normalized and can hardly differentiate whether generated content is credible and acceptable within a higher education context. Equally, Choi *et al.* (2023) alarm that students reverting to such writing mills are mostly lack knowledge that the content produced may harbor very little credibility. Research experiments conducted across various business education disciplines, including business management, microeconomics and accounting (INSEAD, 2023; Wood *et al.*, 2023), provide evidence that ChatGPT still lacks accuracy and fails to answer exam questions effectively, particularly those requiring critical analysis and reasoning, as well as mathematical-type and workout questions.

Issues associated with the use of GenAI, such as algorithmic bias, reasoning limitations, inaccuracy and factual errors, must be carefully addressed. Đerić *et al.* (2025) argue that GenAI-generated content may be inaccurate, biased or even harmful, depending on the validity of the data models on which it has been trained. In this context, Zhao *et al.* (2024) strongly underlined the need to explore these limitations of the usage of ChatGPT among students, as they might lead to biased and skewed knowledge among students. Consequently, this will affect the outcome of their educational process. The reason for this could be attributed to the fact that the LLMs are trained on the basis of the big data provided by sources such as Google, Reddit, blogging sites, wiki pages and consumer reviews. This impacts and shapes the capability of the algorithm for information production (Cooper, 2023; Zhao *et al.*, 2024). Additionally, the literature shows the fact that the applications of AI are based on the algorithms replicated again and again for the purposes of patterned information and predictive texts for the development of information and development of writing prompts (Dakakni *et al.*, 2023; Elbanna and Armstrong, 2024; Sweeney, 2023). However, in such cases, the results are less authentic; neither credible nor realistic in the context of real data (Sweeney, 2023; Dakakni *et al.*, 2023; Choi *et al.*, 2023; Cooper, 2023). In such contexts, the imperfection of ChatGPT at the level of fabricating facts leads to inconsistent and unpredictable results, the authenticity of which must be verified (Elbanna and Armstrong, 2024). Additionally, the GenAI tools lack the capability for validating their produced content, at least in the context of identifying information, misinformation and falsehoods (Cooper, 2023). Therefore, the final outcome from the use of GenAI requires checks at the level of human intervention (Cooper, 2023).

3. Methodology

3.1 Sampling

The semi-structured interview method has been used to examine the possible impact of GenAI, such as ChatGPT, on the topic of academic integrity in higher education. This method has been used to gain insights into how harnessing this tool despite the challenges and ethical concerns involved, as per the views and opinions of accounting educators. This type of research method allows greater exposure to the experiences and opinions of the participants. In fact, immersion in the experiences and opinions of academics seems very important for gaining a deeper understanding of the complexities involved in implementing GenAI at the higher education level (Flick, 2022).

Participants were initially identified via LinkedIn based on their academic expertise and research focus. Polite invitations were sent out to seek their tentative agreement to participate

in the study. The messaging about the invitation included the introduction of the researcher as well as the details of the proposed study. This included the aim, significance and potential impact of the proposed study, as well as assurance of confidentiality and encouragement to participate. Among the 66 messages that were sent to the academics invited to the proposed study, 17 accounting professors in the UK universities agreed to join the proposed study. Some professors declined due to their lack of familiarity with Generative AI applications. Fortunately, the participants were of diverse ranks as assistants, readers, principal lecturers, associate professors and full professors, as outlined in [Appendix 1](#).

3.2 Interview protocol

Prior to embarking on the interviews, a semi-structured interview protocol has been developed. This has been achieved to ensure the extraction of in-depth information that reflects the concepts studied ([Creswell and Creswell, 2017](#)). In the development of the interview protocol, the following steps were considered: (1) A review of the existing body of knowledge related to the usage of GenAI in the context of higher education (for example: [McKinsey, 2023](#); [Zhai et al., 2024](#); [Sweeney, 2023](#); [Dakakni et al., 2023](#); [Wood et al., 2023](#); [Ballantine et al., 2024](#)), as well as the underpinning theoretical aspects (academic integrity framework and the institutional theory), (2) the domain knowledge of academics who are experts in AI-related research and educational aspects and (3) the interview has been pre-tested by piloting it among the initial set of subjects proposed, including three accounting professors. The semi-structural design gave the interviewees a structured context that allowed for open answers. This helped the researcher tap into specific information as per the experiences of each professor ([Creswell and Creswell, 2017](#)). The final interview protocol ([Appendix 2](#)) has 4 themes and 14 questions:

- (1) Background Information (3 questions): This category focuses on the educational background and experience of the subjects as well as their familiarity levels with the GenAI.
- (2) Misuse of AI and Academic Integrity (2 questions): The misuse of AI related to overreliance, cheating, plagiarism, the potential impact of AI on academic integrity and investigate how academics identify the distinction between ethical use of AI and misconduct.
- (3) Ethical issues (2 questions): This category focuses on bias, inaccuracy, data privacy and security risks associated with GenAI.
- (4) Potential Solutions (7 questions): Seeks accounting educators' perspectives on how addressing ethical concerns through using different strategies for AI integration, assessment methods, the educator's role, academic policies, regulatory frameworks, training and AI literacy.

3.3 Data collection and analysis

After completing the ethics approval and the process of gaining informed consent, the actual data generation involved remote interviews conducted between February 2024 and December 2024. The time required for each interview was between 45 and 75 min. Each interview session involved the use of recording with a participant's agreement. For the interviewees who were not recorded, a note-taking process related to the information gathered took place. This involved the transcription of the information gathered immediately after the end of the interview. Thematic analysis was used for the generation of themes to improve the transparency and reproducibility of the information gathered ([Braun and Clarke, 2006](#)). The procedure involved multiple readings of the transcripts and followed by initial descriptive coding of meaningful units. The codes were also grouped into categories and finally reduced

into broader themes by iteration. An initial coding book containing the definition of codes and the exclusion and inclusion criteria, as well as example quotes, has been created for the first three transcripts and applied consistently to the remainder of the dataset. All coding procedures have been performed manually. This has been followed by an independent checking of a subset of the data for the purposes of improving reliability. The final themes were compared against the context of the existing literature (Creswell *et al.*, 2017; Doyle *et al.*, 2020), thereby allowing the construction of meaning without diminishing participants' unique understandings. This systemic approach allowed for boosting the quality of thematic final results in terms of the reliability of interpretation. This, in turn, helped create thoughtful analyses related to how accounting professors understand the presented ethical issues related to GenAI in the context of accounting education.

3.4 Participants background

Participants tend to have sufficient experience at the time of teaching accounting education due to the fact that their teaching experience ranges between 4 and 23 years, as per the corresponding holder of the position. In addition to that, the faculty members get diverse academic ranks, namely associate professor, reader, principal lecturer, associate professor and full professor. All the participants are aware of the usage of the GenAI tools. However, the usage level of the participants tends to remain different. Most of the participants have been recognized to use different GenAI tools for the purposes of formulating the exercise activities and simulations, assignments and research activities. Appendix 2 shows the demographics of the participants.

4. Findings

4.1 Challenges, threats and ethical considerations

4.1.1 Academic integrity and misuse of AI. AI tools can increase the likelihood of students cheating by utilizing these tools for automating assignments or creating shortcuts instead of participating wholeheartedly in the learning process (Dakakni *et al.*, 2023; Ballantine *et al.*, 2024). The misuse of AI tools in academic misconduct among students for activities like cheating, overreliance and dishonesty has been identified by interviewees as a serious ethical concern:

... we face with AI in education is the risk of students becoming overly reliant on it in completing their assignments ... a way for easy and cheap cheating. (Associate professor, 7)

The potential for academic misconduct and dishonesty is real, especially with AI tools becoming more accessible. (Full professor, 16)

... While ChatGPT offers tremendous potential for learning enhancement, it also presents the risk of overreliance and shortcuts. (Principal lecturer, 1)

... It represents a big challenge, especially for those who seek "fast-food-like" intellectual production (essays, assignments, and working papers). If this practice is not properly governed and controlled, academia will be seriously endangered and will gradually lose its status in society. (Reader, 15)

Participants also identified cheating, inaccuracy, fabricated citations and heavily relying on AI-generated content as major challenges, emphasizing that AI detection tools, with continuous development of technology, still fail to detect academic misconduct such as cheating and plagiarism, with some of our interviewees noting that:

I've had instances where entire assignments were clearly AI-generated, but current detection tools often fail to flag them. (Associate professor, 6)

In one case, a student submitted a financial statement analysis that was entirely AI-generated and riddled with errors. (reader, 9)

Students submit references that don't exist because the AI invented them; it is a new form of academic dishonesty. (Reader, 14)

... even updated versions from Turnitin are often unable to identify and addressing cheating and plagiarism with advances of GenAI features ... So, educators are left playing catch-up as the situation evolves around them. (Full professor, 17)

Furthermore, most participants agreed on how challenging to draw a clear line between ethical use and misuse. Specific examples included students using AI to write essays, solve accounting problems and generate financial models, as outlined by two assistant professors as follows:

When students use AI for initial research, it's fine, but submitting unedited AI-generated work as their own is unacceptable. (Principal lecturer, 3)

For me I think it is hard to draw a line between legitimate and unethical AI use, however, it is so problematic and I so skeptical towards AI. (Reader, 10)

4.1.2 Bias, data privacy and transparency. Utilization of AI in education also raises several ethical concerns, especially regarding bias, data privacy and transparency. AI algorithms are often trained on historical data, which can include biases that reflect social inequalities (Chan and Hu, 2023; Sweeney, 2023). As such, it is important that educators understand the disadvantages and limitations of AI models and make efforts not to solidify bias into learning outcomes or assessment methods. In addition, the process of gathering data for the students for the development of AI systems must be carried out cautiously, such that the right of privacy for the students is not overstepped (Dakakni *et al.*, 2023). Additionally, the aspect of the privacy of the students must be clear, such that the students understand the use of their information and how their privacy is handled. To delve deeper into this, the questions on these concerns have been asked of the interviewees, and some of the responses are replicated below:

The ethical implications of AI in education cannot be overlooked. Bias in AI algorithms is a significant concern, as these systems are often trained on historical data that may reinforce existing social inequalities. It is crucial for educators to be aware of these risks to avoid perpetuating biased outcomes in student assessments. (Reader, 13)

Data privacy is a major issue when it comes to AI use in education. AI-driven systems collect vast amounts of student data, and without strict guidelines, this data could be misused or mishandled. Institutions must be transparent about how student data is being used and ensure that privacy standards are upheld. (Associate professor, 7)

In addition, the possible replacement of some aspects of the educator's role by AI may result in the reduction of the human aspect in the education process and may affect the normal development of the students (Jogaroo *et al.*, 2024). Additionally, ethical AI design must avoid exploiting human psychological vulnerabilities. AI systems, especially in educational settings, should prioritize transparency and fairness, ensuring they support student development without manipulation or coercion.

AI offers remarkable opportunities for enhancing education, but there are real concerns about its potential to replace human educators and human psychological vulnerabilities. (Principal lecturer, 2)

Another point we must add here, as some of our respondents highlighted under ethical concerns the GenAI failure to provide emotional intelligence and moral judgment. These two traits, till the moment, are natural human exclusive abilities and GenAI cannot perform (De Bruyn, 2023). Promoting these qualities within students and train them to give accountable and ethical judgment needs human interaction, exercise and real-life scenarios to examine and work on. This highlights some of the major challenges to GenAI in education in general and accounting education in particular.

The diminishing role of teachers in AI-driven classrooms could impact the holistic development of students, as certain aspects of education such as “emotional intelligence and ethical judgment” are best cultivated through human interaction. (Reader, 12)

4.2 Solutions of AI challenges, threats and ethical concerns

From the insights provided by respondents, it is evident that utilizing AI in education as a strategy for active learning is inevitable. However, its integration must be handled with care and an awareness of its limitations and ethical breaches. Professors suggested several solutions to address the ethical challenges of AI use in education, ensuring its effective integration into accounting education. Strategies involve making strategic planning for the integration of AI, changing the way evaluations are conducted and the role of instructors in the process, offering clear directions, formulating open policies and regulatory systems, cultivating digital citizenship and promoting literacy concerning the ethical issues surrounding AI among students and faculty members.

4.2.1 Strategic integration of GenAI. AI incorporation in the field of accounting education should be strategically planned and gradually involved in the accounting curricula to align with pedagogical objectives. The best ways to incorporate AI have been found to involve the use of AI at different levels in accounting education. This should involve the use of AI in basic accounting courses to perform basic tasks, such as doing calculations for more complex financial scenarios for advanced analyses (Brabete *et al.*, 2024; Jiao, 2024). Ethical use of AI can be emphasized by instructors by, for example, training students on how to implement responsible use of AI. While training accounting students in the use of AI, instructors should highlight the ethical aspects of AI usage. An example of how instructors should highlight the ethical aspect of AI usage during training encompasses training the students in AI ethical usage. This will assist the students in not only being proficient in AI usage but also in applying the appropriate ethics and ethical judgment, which are critically required for accounting professionals (Holmes and Douglass, 2022). Some of our participants have elaborated on this particular part as follows:

The strategic integration of AI into our curricula is essential for preparing students for the changing demands of the accounting profession. We need to think beyond just teaching the technical use of AI tools and focus on embedding them across all levels of education . . . This includes development of an understanding of AI's ethical implications, as this awareness is critical for developing professionals who can navigate the complex ethical landscape of modern accounting. (Full professor, 16)

. . . There is a need for accounting schools to immerse GenAI into the students experience to provide them with skills for the future. However, There must be a strategic balance to be strike with academic integrity and maintaining standards. (Principal lecturer, 4)

AI can be a powerful teaching assistant, but it should strategically integrated as complement, not replace, traditional methods. (Reader, 12)

4.2.2 Assessment methods and educators' role. Professors emphasize the role of accounting educators to mitigate academic misconduct and student dishonesty in their assignments. Academics should highlight the role of AI as a complement rather than a substitute in the human learning process. They should play a pivotal role in shaping the understanding of the students that the role of AI is a complement rather than a substitute in the development of critical thinking and problem-solving abilities. Moreover, instructors should incorporate various assignment forms related to higher-order thinking, such as case studies and group projects, can increase the chances of less cheating and dishonesty in academic circles (Perkins and Roe, 2024; Wood and Moss, 2024; Dakakni *et al.*, 2023). In the context given above, the following are the insights derived from the interviews conducted, as presented below:

... There is a fine line between using AI as a tool for learning and using it as a shortcut. It is up to us as educators to reinforce the idea that AI should supplement, not replace, critical thinking and engagement. (Assistant, 6)

We must design assessments that push students beyond mere automation, like case studies or collaborative projects that require higher-order thinking. These approaches not only mitigate misuse but also encourage deeper learning. (Full professor, 17)

In-class open-book exams and case studies could limit AI misuse while encouraging critical thinking. (Full professor, 17).

AI-friendly assessments and simulations, for example, presentations, case studies and group projects, have the capability to offer a solid foundation for the promotion of Academic Integrity while at the same time functioning according to the requirements of the international professional practices (Narciso, 2024; Jiao, 2024). These assessments are very engaging since they require critical analysis, active participation and group work. Therefore, it may be harder for the students to cheat using AIs entirely, and at the same time motivates them to verify the information and attempt to offer their own contribution. The capability for simulations of the real corporate setting, offered by GenAI tools, motivates the students to transfer theoretical knowledge to practice and develop skills such as communication skills, problem-solving and ethical reasoning. Such assessment and evaluation approaches enable preventing cheating and uphold the integrity of academic evaluations, and at the same time aids in equipping students with competencies directly relevant to their future careers.

AI-friendly assessments like case studies and collaborative projects are effective in establishing real-world skills while maintaining academic integrity. These formats demand originality and teamwork, making it less likely for students to misuse AI tools while preparing them for professional challenges. (Reader, 10)

Presentations and case-based evaluations mimic professional scenarios, ensuring that students not only understand theoretical concepts but also know how to apply them practically. These methods reflect the demands of the modern workplace while safeguarding the integrity of academic assessments. (Principal lecturer, 1)

Other educators suggested pairing take-home, open-book exams and assignments with traditional assessments to minimize risks and ensure that students understand and undergo critical analysis of the information obtained using GenAI outputs.

AI generated text is NOT plagiarism. The problem is mixing AI with plagiarism. We need to adopt the new technology and not become like the math teachers whom protested the use of calculators by students. I believe that our assessment techniques must change and not simply ask students to write a "term paper". (Associate professor, 8)

in preventing cheating and plagiarism, I suggest to minimise the use of our traditional forms of theoretical written assessments, and replace them with these with in-class examination and practical assessments, which GenAI still fail to perfectly answer it, such preparation of financial statement and financial analysis. (Assistant professor, 4) (Reader, 15)

Instructors play a crucial role to prevent students misconduct by informing them what is required in the future assignments ... by providing clear guidance on assignment by assignment basis on how they are ethically allowed utilising AI, so they do not accidentally fall in academic misconduct. ... Without this guidance, students might get lost in the grey area. (Reader, 12)

I do not care whether the students use AI tools for completing their home works and assignments as long as I required them to orally discuss them in the classroom. (Principal lecturer, 4)

4.2.3 Transparent academic policies and clear guidance. Transparent academic policies about the application of AI can play a pivotal role in starting the process of building trust

among students and faculty (Chan, 2023). Clear academic guidelines on how AI can be responsibly utilized might ensure its effective and ethical implementation in the academic work, through reducing confusion and building confidence in its use. Universities must undertake proactive actions in updating their academic conduct policies to encounter the related to the challenges raised due to the highly accelerated application of AI tools. As a result, the establishment of equitable and transparent policies may enable institutions to create a framework that supports ethical and responsible AI use; and hence maintaining academic integrity.

Transparent academic policies on AI use can transform uncertainty into trust, enabling both students and educators to leverage AI ethically. These guidelines provide clarity in a changing landscape. (Assistant professor, 4)

Universities must refresh their academic conduct policies to address AI's challenges, ensuring clarity and fairness in its integration. Without such updates, the gap between policy and practice will only grow. (Associate professor, 8)

Policies must be also customised to address the specific need of each department, not one policy fit for all (Full professor, 17)

Participants indicate that, in many cases, students tend to mention incidents of misusing AI unintentionally; this creates the need for the dissemination of clear instructions and the teaching of the proper usage of AI (Wang *et al.*, 2024). This might be due to a lack of proper understanding of the abilities and the potential moral issues of AI. The issuance of clear polices and continued support, therefore, can help enable educators to enable students to navigate the tools with confidence. Furthermore, empowering students with the knowledge to use AI responsibly not only alleviates fears but further fosters a culture of ethical use of technology that extends into their professional lives.

Clear and ongoing guidance is critical to address students' anxieties about accidentally misusing AI in their academic journey. Educators must take the lead in demystifying AI and its ethical implications. (Reader, 13)

Empowering students with knowledge about ethical AI use helps build confidence and reduces fears of unintentional violations. This knowledge is a critical foundation for responsible technology use. (Reader, 10)

Institutions must establish policies on acceptable AI use in education I am with allowing students to use AI, but with guidance and they must instructed to submit a statement of AI use when used, and how and where used (Principal lecturer, 2)

4.2.4 Establishment of regularity framework. The development of regulatory frameworks has become a significant factor in the safe incorporation of AI in the educational process (Cancela-Outeda, 2024). Adherence to the steadily developing regularity standards has not only proven effective in reducing the threats but has also helped in fostering trust among the students, instructors and institutions. HEIs can develop a long-term basis for adopting AI solutions when the incorporation process of AI integrates ethical standards and legal principles. Adherence to the frameworks may ensure the applications of AI do not impair the learning experiences of students, while at the same time do not impair the ethical considerations of privacy, security and fairness.

Establishment of AI regulations ensures safe and transparent adoption in education. These standards provide a necessary foundation for responsible innovation. (Principal lecturer, 2)

Compliance with ethical and legal standards is non-negotiable for sustainable AI integration in higher education. It creates a framework that protects all stakeholders while advancing educational outcomes. (Assistant professor, 5)

For there to be a balance between the innovation and regulation aspects, the promotion of the responsible use of AI in learning must be achieved (Zhao, 2024). Applied and proper regulation ensures the promotion of the ethical use of AI among the learners for the objective of protecting the user from the harmful effects, as well as the establishment of trust (Zhao, 2024). However, the regulation process, which may be seen as overreaching may result in the absence of the process of innovation for the purposes of the development of innovative solutions for the transformative learning environments. This ensures the institution takes the benefits of the AI while still adhering to the ethical aspects.

Balancing innovation with regulation ensures that AI advances education responsibly, without stifling creativity. This equilibrium is crucial for sustainable progress in educational technology. (Reader, 9)

Ethical AI adoption requires thoughtful regulation to protect users while ensuring technological progress. This dual approach ensures that we benefit from AI's potential while mitigating risks. (Full professor, 16)

4.2.5 Diffusion of AI literacy and faculty development. The issue of ensuring the ethical uses of AI goes beyond the school context to the uses of AI in other spheres of life (Sweeney, 2023). Notably, the fact that AI will continue to affect every aspect of human life as time goes by, the aspect of completing the journey of AI literacy among students must factor in the aspect of dealing not only with the implications associated within the context of the school setting, but also other spheres of human activity and society as well. Such other spheres of human activity associated with the implications of AI include the aspects of bias, data privacy, among others, associated with the algorithms used in AI systems, such as robotics and machine learning.

The future of AI education lies in teaching students to apply AI ethically, not just in academia, but across industries and daily life. This prepares them to make informed decisions in a tech-driven world. (Reader, 12)

... we must educate students on how to use AI tools to achieve different tasks. Through a rigorous process and AI literacy, we ensure students can utilise AI effectively in favour of the educational process. (Principal lecturer, 1)

Knowledge and expertise of faculty members in the area of AI play a vital role in the effective implementation of AI in the educational field (Celik, 2023). When faculty members have in-depth knowledge about the AI tools used today and their effects, they can easily demonstrate to the students the opportunities as well as the threats of the AI technology. In-depth training for faculty members will not only teach them how to deliver lessons about AI concepts but also how to tackle the complexities associated with AI. Some of the faculty members expressed the following:

Equipping educators with AI expertise is the cornerstone of striking a balanced and effective integration of technology in education. Without informed educators, AI's potential remains underutilized. (Reader, 14)

Faculty training in AI ensures that educators can confidently guide students through its opportunities and ethical complexities. This is essential for preparing students to use AI responsibly in their professional lives. (Principal lecturer, 4)

I believe educators need to understand and learn more about these tools ... The problem is not AI, the problem is educators need to develop and re-evaluate their teaching methods (Associate professor, 8)

4.3 Summary of findings and discussion

The interviews have shown that accounting educators view GenAI as both a threat and an opportunity. Five dominant themes emerged. The primary concern raised by professors is its

impact on academic integrity. The interviewees referred to the growing trend of misusing GenAI among their students through cheating, plagiarism, fabricated references and overreliance on AI-generated content. While the interviewees conceded the fact that detection systems, such as Turnitin, sometimes identified the use of GenAI, the majority expressed their doubts about the tools' effectiveness. They also pointed out that boundaries between legitimate learning support and misconduct are loose and hazy. This finding can also be considered as representing the pressing concern related to the protection of academic integrity in today's world, where AI systems can easily be accessed (Holmes and Douglass, 2022; Dakakni *et al.*, 2023).

In addition to the aspect of integrity, the educators also raised other important issues related to ethical conduct. For instance, the educators expressed concern about the misinformation, algorithmic bias and data privacy, as well as the lack of human touch in the AI outputs in terms of human judgment, empathy and contextual reasoning. In fact, the participants highlighted how the overdependence on GenAI might affect the critical thinking and problem-solving capacities of students without the support of GenAI. Notably, this sentiment agrees with the concern held by De Bruyn (2023), and other scholars mentioned earlier. Nevertheless, the participants were not against the utilization of GenAI, as the professors are able to recognize the benefits GenAI might bring to the teaching process in a certain context. For example, the participants highlighted the capability of GenAI to brainstorm ideas for students, explain accounting standards, as well as financial ratio analysis, among other technical aspects. Importantly, however, the participants emphasized keeping such uses within the purview of complementarity and not subservient to the effort of students without GenAI's capability. Again, this resonates with scholars' studies about the catalyst role GenAI might play within the pedagogic transformative process within the context of the right scaffolded uses mentioned earlier (Ballantine *et al.*, 2024; Wang *et al.*, 2024).

The analysis of the interviews also reiterated the importance of reconsidering assessment strategies. Lecturers suggested that traditional written assignments became ever more susceptible to the misusing of AI technologies. They suggested the need for enhanced utilization of projects based on cases, oral exams and presentations requiring higher-order thinking skills. In addition to this, they reiterated their own personal role as guides who are expected to be accountable for the demonstration of ethical practice in the utilization of such technologies, right up to the development of students' disposition toward ethical practice as well. The points raised about the refocusing of assessment strategies and the role of the educator reflect the debates about the importance of establishing new pedagogical approaches in addition to new rules for the purposes of the promotion of academic integrity (Wood *et al.*, 2023; Choi *et al.*, 2023; Ballantine *et al.*, 2024; Narciso, 2024; Perkins and Roe, 2024). Lastly, the participants raised points about the significance of the support of rules by institutions for the purposes of the utilization of the technologies. They argued for the provision of clear guidelines on the acceptable use of AI technologies, training programs to be provided to both staff and students. To the latter, the suggested training should comprise for students for the acquisition of technical skills needed of right use of AI technologies, in addition to ethical awareness for the proper management of such technologies at the same time. To the former staff members, enhanced confidence should be established concerning the management of the integration of the said technologies into their curricular provision. Such findings mirror broader ongoing discussions and debates that emphasize that the AI adoption must be underpinned by strong institutional culture and regulatory frameworks (Chan, 2023; Ballantine *et al.*, 2024; Sweeny, 2023). Table 1 summarize the key findings of the research:

4.4 Contributions and implications

This article contributes to the field of AI in higher education as it finds its roots in the context of debates surrounding academic integrity, ethics and the influence of AI and related technological advancements. The findings presented above demonstrate the conflict between the

Table 1. Summary of key findings

Theme	Key findings
Academic integrity	Misuse of AI for plagiarism, fabricated references, overreliance on AI-generated content; limitations of detection tools
Ethical concerns	Misinformation, algorithmic bias, data privacy, lack of human judgment and empathy in AI outputs
Impact on critical skills	Risk of undermining critical thinking and independent problem-solving
Pedagogical opportunities	Potential use for brainstorming, clarifying accounting standards, supporting technical tasks, as long as it complements student effort
Potential solutions	Need for strategic integration of AI, including the educators role, redesigned assessments (case-based, oral, presentations), clearer institutional policy and regulations, faculty guidance and AI literacy programs

Source(s): Author’s own work

opportunities and misuse of AI and how the era of disruption described in the context of organizational theory affects the HEIs, where their established norms and practices are challenged by emergent technologies. In other words, universities are finding themselves between the demands and pressures of multiple stakeholders, including students, regulatory authorities, the business world and society as a whole, to maintain their legitimacy while adapting to change. This can also be addressed through the Academic Integrity framework as described in the context of honesty, trust, fairness, respect, responsibility and the virtue of courage (Fishman, 2014; Bretag, 2016), thereby realising how GenAI undermines or upholds the fundamental principles of the Academic world.

This study has several implications for policymakers, pedagogical delivery techniques, as well as the broader society. For policymakers, the finding clearly indicates the immense urgency of implementing proper policies for the usage of AI at the university level. According to the theory of institutions, when innovative techniques disrupt the existing structure of the firm, institutions exhibit the behavior of mimicry or symbolic acceptance. Yet, the educational administrators interviewed for the publication made it clear that merely changing the policies at universities won’t accomplish the goal. Instead, universities should incorporate an AI governance structure that focuses on privacy, fairness and responsibility.

On the pedagogical aspect, the findings of this study bring to the fore the importance of restructuring the curriculum and the assessment process to fit the reality of the learning made possible through the use of AI. The traditional methods employed in the process of assessment and testing are slowly falling prey to the possibility of misconduct. This highlights the need to integrate the activity phases associated with the promotion of higher-order thinking processes and ethical judgments. GenAI may also be employed for the purposes of facilitating the process of problem-solving and technical support for studies in the field of accountancy, although the aspect may be dealt with in such a manner as not to create harmful dependency. This highlights the subsequent point associated with the fact that the AI should actually power the process of re-designing the process of education. Critical thinking, ethics and digital citizenship must form the basis for the success of current and future educational outcomes.

While the insights gained above relate specifically to higher education, the applicability to K-12 education should not be dismissed. AI literacy and ethical reasoning should form the basis of K-12 education to equip students for the effective use of AI in their future studies. The curriculum developers at the K-12 level could incorporate modules for problem-solving and ethical thought, as well as digital citizenship lessons. In this way, although the development process of ethical use of GenAI in accounting education represents a remarkable case relative to preserving the quality of education at academic institutions concerned with upholding integrity in academia, rather more importantly marks the latest development toward meeting the rising demands at the workplace relative to appropriate literacy and ethical rationality.

In a broader societal perspective, the implications arising from the study highlight the specific concern of how accountancy graduates might increase the unethical behavior post-learning the use of AI, when the accountancy graduates demonstrate more unethical propensities as a carryover effect from their AI-learning experiences. On the other hand, the training of accountancy students in the literacy of AI and ethics can adequately prepare them for the correct management of the future AI-driven world of work. As such, the implication of utilizing AI in accountancy education in a responsible manner encompasses aspects of maintaining academic integrity as well as the accountancy profession's role in maintaining the credence of financial reporting.

4.5 Conclusion

Though the role of GenAI in higher education is a hot topic across the world, in the present research, the significance of GenAI in the context of academic integrity in accounting education assumes prominence. This present research discusses the risks, challenges and ethical concerns related to the use of GenAI from the perspective of accounting educators. Results obtained clearly disclose that the management of academic integrity and ethical complexities related to honesty, overreliance, fairness, bias and ethics related to GenAI assumes equal importance. Suggested solutions stressed through the perspective of educators include the strategic integration of AI in the curriculum of accounting education at the appropriate level, revised assessment approaches and enhanced role of instructors, clear institutional policies and guidelines and enhanced AI literacy.

This study extends the current body of knowledge on AI in the higher education context by incorporating insights on the realm of academic integrity, digital ethics and strategic AI implementation in accounting education. By placing the debate specifically in the context of academic integrity, as described under the framework of honesty, trust, fairness, respect, responsibility and courage, the role of AI implementation in the context of the interplay between AI implementation and the fundamental principles of academia comes to the fore. This study informs the realm of institutional theory with regard to the effects of the disruptions triggered in the context of AI implementation. Taken into consideration the importance of the results achieved, there comes the imperative need for the redefined reactivity of the contemporary universities' response to the challenges posed by the implementation of AI and to move on toward a proactive approach for the development of a positive culture within the context of the norms the principles of academic integrity. Through such an approach, the higher education institutions will be able to convert the GenAI from the "threat" to the "opportunity" within the context of the pedagogical renewal and simultaneously will be able to safeguard academic Integrity.

This study has many limitations relevant to its qualitative approach, which limit generalizability of findings, as well as the limited focus on educators' perspectives in the accounting field, which may not fully capture students own experiences, neither document other disciplinary perspectives. Future research can engage in quantitative studies to explore student attitudes toward ethical AI practices and examine the long-term impact of AI on learning outcomes and professional readiness. Additionally, further studies could investigate academic integrity and ethical conduct in other disciplines to gain overarching understanding of this topic and compare AI adoption strategies across different academic fields. Future studies can also explore the potential of GenAI on fostering an active learning approach, soft skills development, as well as how it can affect students' mental health and well-being.

(The Appendix follows overleaf)

Appendix 1

Table A1. Participants' demographics

Interviewee	Position	Years of experience
1	Principal lecturer	5
2	Principal lecturer	7
3	Principal lecturer	4
4	Principal lecturer	4
5	Assistant professor	6
6	Assistant professor	5
7	Associate professor	8
8	Associate professor	10
9	Reader	9
10	Reader	11
11	Reader	17
12	Reader	12
13	Reader	11
14	Reader	10
15	Reader	15
16	Full professor	23
17	Full professor	19

Source(s): Author's own work

Appendix 2

Table A2. Interview questions

Interview protocol
<i>Section 1: Background Information</i> (1) Can you briefly describe your academic background and experience in accounting education? (2) How familiar are you with Generative AI tools (e.g. ChatGPT) in the academic context? (3) Do you use AI tools in your teaching, research or assessment methods? If so, how? <i>Section 2: Academic Integrity and Misuse of AI</i> (4) What ethical concerns and challenges do you associate with AI use in academic integrity and misconduct? For example, cheating, plagiarism and dishonesty (5) How do you differentiate between legitimate AI-supported learning and unethical practices like plagiarism or over-reliance on AI-generated content? <i>Section 3: Ethical Concerns – Bias, Data Privacy and Transparency</i> (6) AI tools are often trained on biased data, leading to inequitable learning outcomes. Have you observed any biased or inaccurate AI-generated responses? (7) Data privacy is a growing concern in AI-driven education. Are you concerned about data privacy and security in AI-driven education? <i>Section 4: Solutions to AI Challenges, Threats and Ethical Concerns</i> 1. <i>Strategic Integration of GenAI in Accounting Education</i> (1) How can AI be strategically integrated into accounting curricula while maintaining academic integrity? 2. <i>Assessment Methods and Educators' Role</i> (2) <i>How can assessment methods be redesigned to minimize AI misuse?</i> (3) What role should Accounting educators play in guiding students toward ethical AI use? 3. <i>Policies and Regulatory Frameworks</i> (4) What institutional policies should be implemented to ensure clear guidelines on AI use in academia? (5) Should universities establish formal AI regulations and if so, what key elements should they include? 4. <i>AI Literacy and Faculty Development</i> (6) How important is AI literacy for both students and faculty in addressing ethical concerns and responsible AI adoption? (7) What institutional support (e.g. training, AI detection tools) is needed to help educators navigate AI integration effectively?
Source(s): Author's own work

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